Michael F Bergmann

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Employment

2024-01 – present	Associate Professor (Tenured), Performance, The Creative School, Toronto Metropolitan University
2022-07 – 2023-07	Co-Undergraduate Program Director (Production), Performance, The Creative School, TMU
2019-08 – 2024-01	Assistant Professor, Performance, The Creative School, Toronto Metropolitan University
2017 – present	Full Member, Yeates School of Graduate Studies, TMU
2016-08 – 2019-08	Assistant Professor (Limited Term Faculty), Performance, The Creative School, TMU
2014 – 2016	Technology Specialist / Media Server Programmer, WorldStage LAB, San Francisco / New York
2007 – 2010	Projection Specialist, Meet The Dude Productions, Toronto

Education

2022-09 – present	PhD Candidate, Critical Studies in Improvisation, University of Guelph. Expected 2027.
2011 – 2014	MFA, Design (Projection Design Specialization), Yale School of Drama, Yale University
2006 – 2011	BFA, Theatre Performance Production, Ryerson Theatre School, Toronto Metropolitan University (coursework completed December 2010; graduated May 2011)

Teaching, Training, and Certifications

2020	Teaching Adult Learners Online, Chang School of Continuing Education, TMU
2019	SEDA Recognised Teacher, University Teaching Development Programme (SEDA, UK and Ireland)
2019	Apple Certified Teacher, Apple
2018	Watchout Certified User and Operator, Dataton
2015	Pandoras Box Media Server Training (Basic, Advanced, Expert Warping & Particles, Widget Designer), coolux

Awards and Distinctions

2022	Best World Feature Film: Nuptials, Austin Revolution Film Festival (as producer)
2014	Best Production: He Left Quietly, SummerWorks Performance Festival (as designer)
2012 – 2014	Eldon Elder Fellowship, Yale University ($40,000 USD; held throughout the MFA)
2009	Spirit of the Fringe, Prague Fringe Festival
2006	Short-listed, Prix Molière, Theatre Glendon

Residencies and Invited Positions

2025-12 – 2026-02	Mentor, Setsubun Digital Media Residency, Japanese Canadian Cultural Centre, Toronto
2024-06	Artist-in-residence, SÍM Residency (with UKAI Projects), Reykjavík, Iceland — Shipwreck, June 2–30, 2024
2022-04	Artist-in-residence, Ingenuity Labs Research Institute, Queen's University, Kingston
2021-10 – 2022-10	Ferment AI Residency artist; residency output presented in Berlin, October 2022

Publications

2022-07	Bouchard, D., Cristiá, C., Robert, D., and Bergmann, M. (2022). "Augmented Symphony: An augmented reality application for immersive music listening." Proceedings of EVA London 2022, Electronic Workshops in Computing, BCS Learning & Development, London, UK, July 4–8, 2022, pp. 208–209. DOI: 10.14236/ewic/EVA2022.39.
2022-05	Cristiá, C., Bouchard, D., Bergmann, M., et al. (2022). Orchestra Remote Delivery during COVID-19 Database. Open data set, Open Science Framework, May 5, 2022. DOI: 10.17605/OSF.IO/WCDU2.
2021	Bergmann, M. F., and McGuire, B. (2021). "Uncanny Text." Belfield Literary Review: New TransAtlantic Dialogues, ed. Gregory Betts and Lucy Collins, Spring 2021, pp. 96–99.
2017-11	Bergmann, M. F. (2017). "Performance Art: New Magic." Rough Draft, Vol. 2, No. 1, ed. Laurence Butet-Roch, November 7, 2017.

Forthcoming

2026 Bergmann, M. “Cultivating Empathy through Robotic Performance.” Chapter in Robots and Other Artificial Agents on Stage: Theoretical Concepts and Artistic Practices, edited by Erica Magris and Izabella Pluta, transcript Verlag (Theatre Studies series). [in press]

2026 Bergmann, M., and McLeod, K. “Improvising with Commercial AI: Questions of Care and Ethics.” [in draft]

Conference Presentations

2025-09 Bergmann, M. “Hallucinating Children: Improvisation After the Algorithmic Shipwreck.” Hugarflug: Unstable Systems, annual conference on artistic research, Iceland University of the Arts, Reykjavík, Iceland, September 12, 2025.

2024-10 Bergmann, M. “Beyond Tools: Reimaging Technology as Co-Participants in Performance Design.” PQ Symposium: Technologies in Theatre, Performance and Exhibition Design, Prague, Czech Republic, October 16–18, 2024.

2024-03 Bergmann, M., Nathan, H., and Vercosa, J. “Robotics, AI, and the Future of Theatre.” USITT Conference & Stage Expo, Seattle, WA, March 20, 2024.

2023-06 Bergmann, M., with ChatGPT. “Envisioning theatre with non-human collaborators: A Paramanifesto.” CATR Conference, Dalhousie University, Halifax, NS, June 2023.

2023-06 Bergmann, M. “AI Sentience.” Panel on the Implications of AI for Performance Theorists, CATR Conference (online), June 2023.

2022-07 Bergmann, M. “Augmented Symphony: An augmented reality application for immersive music listening.” Paper presented at EVA London 2022, London, UK, July 2022.

2022-05 Bergmann, M., and Thomson, B. “Stepping Back In: Taking the best of virtual delivery to a new in-person experience.” Learning & Teaching Conference, TMU, May 2022.

2022-05 Bergmann, M. “Student-driven curriculum development for creative practice.” Learning & Teaching Conference, TMU, May 2022.

2021-10 Bergmann, M. “Cultivating Empathy through Robotic Performance.” Limits of the Human, Machines Without Limits? Contemporary stage and robotics, University of Lausanne (online), October 2021.

2021-06 Bergmann, M., O’Brien, C., and Thomson, B. “Unapologetically learning together: Adapting Production and Design curriculum to a virtual stage.” University of the Arts London (online), June 2021.

2021-05 Bergmann, M., O’Brien, C., and Thomson, B. “Pandemic Performance: Adapting Production and Design curriculum to a virtual stage.” Learning & Teaching Conference, Ryerson University, May 2021.

2019-05	Bergmann, M., and Thomson, B. “Putting Up the Show: The very large group project.” Ryerson Learning & Teaching Conference, May 2019.
2019-04	Bergmann, M. “Theatre in TheatAR: Explorations of augmented reality in theatrical performance.” TEXT/SOUND/PERFORMANCE: Making in Canadian Space, University College Dublin, April 2019.
2018-03	Bergmann, M. “Technology as a tool: Creating a mindset of embracing technology within a theatrical framework.” Theatre and Performance Design Pedagogy, University of the Arts London, March 2018.

Poster Presentations

2024-01	Bergmann, M., Carravetta, L., Endahl, M., Robinson, A. D., and ARIA (AI). “Almost Alchemy.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, January 25, 2024.
2020-11	Bergmann, M., and Anderson, J. “l’automate: Robotic Controlled Apparatuses for Circus Performance.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU (online), November 2020.
2019-11	Bergmann, M., Zhang, L., Laberge-Côté, L., and McGuire, B. “Human-robot Interactions in Dance.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, November 2019.
2018-11	Bergmann, M. “TheatAR: A previsualization system for theatrical design.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, November 2018.
2018-05	Bosyy, P., and Bergmann, M. “The Creative Laboratory Project.” Poster, Ryerson Learning & Teaching Conference, May 2018.
2017-10	Bergmann, M. “Shadow-selves: Projection as a medium of exploring reflections of self in Belinda McGuire’s Slaughterhouse/Requiem.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, October 2017.
2017-10	Bergmann, M. “Projecting on film: the surreal effect of rear projected backgrounds in the film Nuptials.” Poster, RUBIX, TMU, October 2017.

Invited Talks and Public Lectures

2025-02	Guest lecture on AI in visual generation, open-source models, and ethical usage, Advanced Professional Projection Design (graduate), Yale University, February 14, 2025.
2024-12	Host: “Beyond the Screen: Exploring AI Personhood and Their Representation in Media.” The Creative School Catalyst, Toronto, December 12, 2024.
2024-11	Closing keynote: “Wellness for who? An examination of wellness through a research-creation student project.” AVARA 2024, OAMK, Oulu, Finland, November 22, 2024.
2024-11	Workshop on projection design, Peterborough Theatre Guild, Peterborough, ON, November 2–3, 2024.

2024-10	Provocation: “Personhood // AI.” UKAI Carnival of Shipwreck, Toronto, October 23, 2024.
2024-07	Invited talk on the future of AI in the creative industries. TechTO: AI, Toronto, July 22, 2024.
2024-04	“Improvnetics: Post-anthropocentric performance and improvisational modes for human-AI play.” IICSI Research Studio Session, ImprovLab, University of Guelph, April 12, 2024.
2024-04	Panelist on the future of AI in creativity and education, 1st Creative AI Symposium, Creative AI Hub, TMU, April 2, 2024.
2022-01	Roundtable: “What is the future of creativity and AI?” with Debashis Sinha, Robert Clapperton, and Richard Lachman, RUBIX, TMU, January 27, 2022.
2019-11	“Research Creation with Michael Bergmann: The Uncanny Robots Project” and “Connecting through live performance” (with Eugènie Pastor, LSBU). The Catalyst @ FCAD, TMU, November 2019.

Creative Research Output

2026-04 – 2026-05	“Before I Was This.” Generative text work. flashDRIVE: Digital Arts Fundraiser Exhibition, InterAccess, Toronto, April 22 – May 9, 2026. Curated by Miriam Arbus.
2026-02	Nuptials (feature film). Producer, projection design, and live in-camera VFX. Directed by Sean Braune, Para-sight Productions. Official release February 13, 2026 (Freestyle Digital Media). Best World Feature Film, Austin Revolution Film Festival, 2022.
2025-11	The Frankenstein Project. Producer, with Debashis Sinha. Performance Studio Theatre, TMU, November 18–22, 2025.
2025-11	291 by Jade O’Keeffe. Projection co-design with Kristen Ferguson; directed by Lisa Dixon. Peterborough Theatre Guild, November 1–15, 2025.
2025-04	“To my creators…” Solo work exhibited at the Creative AI Symposium, TMU, April 2, 2025; created during the SÍM residency, Reykjavík.
2024-11	AVARA 2024 installation. Led eight students in a semester-long research-creation installation presented at AVARA 2024, OAMK, Oulu, Finland.
2024-06	Shipwreck. Group exhibition with UKAI Projects and five Canadian artists, SÍM Gallery, Reykjavík, Iceland, following a month-long residency; includes solo work “To my creators…”
2024-04	Labour and Us. Workshop series (March 14 – April 17, 2024) and performance, co-created and performed with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson; roundtable with Alan Filewod, Tom Scholte, Cynthia Ashperger, and Judith Thompson. ImprovLab, University of Guelph, April 19, 2024.

2024-01	Almost Alchemy. Two 360° video experiences of improvised research-creation performance. RUBIX, TMU, January 25, 2024.
2023-10	"rocketmanperson." Improvised performance with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson. Silence, Guelph, October 1, 2023.
2023-04	"Who's There?" Improvised performance with Lucas Carravetta, Matt Endahl, and Aimée Dawn Robinson. Silence, Guelph, April 1, 2023.
2023	Living Newspaper 2.0. Projection design; directed by Julie Labagnara. George Luscombe Theatre, Toronto.
2019-10	"The Uncanny Robots Project: Phase 1." Research-creation premiere examining human-robot interaction through dance, commissioned for the opening of the Creative Technology Lab @ FCAD, TMU, October 2019.

External Research Funding

2024-05	Erasmus+ staff mobility funding, OAMK, Oulu, Finland
2021	SSHRC Partnership Engage Grant, COVID-19 Special Initiative — "Visual Music: Enhancing the National Arts Centre Orchestra's remote connection with their audience during COVID-19 social restrictions through innovative digital tools." PI: Cintia Cristiá; Co-Is: Michael Bergmann, David Bouchard. $24,620.
2012 – 2014	Eldon Elder Fellowship, Yale University. $40,000 USD.

Internal Research Funding

2024	The Creative School Travel Grant, TMU — Shipwreck Iceland project. $1,000.
2022	TMU Work Study RA Program — "Mechanical Waves: Machine Learning gesture reactive human-robot installation." $3,800.
2022	The Creative School Travel Grant — EVA London conference presentation. $2,000.
2019	Cirque du Soleil Entertainment Group / Future of Live Entertainment Lab — "l'automate: Expanding the possibility of performance through robotics." Co-I with Jonathon Anderson. $7,500.
2019	FCAD Special Seed Grant — The Uncanny Robots Project. $4,000.
2019	The Creative School Travel Grant — UCD Dublin conference presentation. $2,000.
2018	Undergraduate Research Opportunity, OVPRI, Ryerson — "Augmented-Reality based Pre-Visualization system for theatrical spaces." $9,888.

2018	Learning and Teaching Enhancement Fund, Ryerson — “The Creative Laboratory Project.” Co-I with Pavlo Bosyy. $13,000.

Scholarships

2022 – 2026	University of Guelph Graduate Tuition Scholarship. $8,000/yr.
2022 – 2026	University of Guelph University Graduate Scholarship. $7,500/yr.

Graduate Supervision

Completed: 9 Master’s, 0 Doctoral, 0 Postdoctoral. In progress: 0.

2022	Aya Elmeligy, MDM (Second Reader), “Bridging Chasms: An Interactive Projection Mapping Installation for Cross-Cultural Exchange of Information.” 2022.
2021	Emilie Trimbee, MDM (Supervisor), “AR-based Theatrical Design Pre-Visualization using Unreal.” 2021.
2021	Lindsay Christopher, MDM (Supervisor), “Casting and Technology: Revamping the Audition Process.” 2021.
2021	Shelby Bushell, MDM (Supervisor), “Collider: Using Virtual Reality for Immersive Theatre and the Performing Arts.” 2021.
2020	Riley Erin Cooper, MDM (Supervisor), “Happiness In Your Hand: The power of compact Bright Light Therapy.” 2020.
2020	Yerachmiel Paquette, MDM (Supervisor), “The Scoop: How to Protect Your Digital Privacy in the Age of Surveillance Capitalism.” 2020.
2020	Kenyth Thomason, MFA in Technical Direction and Production, Yale University (Reader), “Live Video in Theatrical Productions.” 2020.
2018	Michael Castledine, MDM (Supervisor), “Extending the human umwelt: Reframing our understanding of an environment via mixed reality and digital soundscapes/visualizations.” 2018.
2017	Soo Mahabir, MDM (Supervisor), “The A.I. Storyteller: Perpetuating Orality Using Developments in Machine Learning.” 2017.

Courses Taught

- PFZ 100 — Performance Foundation (F 2025) (created course)
- THP 400 — Creative Performance Studies VII: The Frankenstein Project (F 2025) (created course, with Debashis Sinha)
- FCD 816 — Global Campus Studio (F 2025)
- FCD 230 — New York City Experience: Creative Enterprise (S 2025, S 2026) (created travel intensive; taught as overload)
- THP 403 — Travel Intensive to Oulu, Finland (F 2024)
- THP 350 — Projection Design (F 2019–24) (created course)
- THP 301–403 — Production Technique (W 2017 – F 2022)

- THP 800 — Independent Study (W 2017–20, F 2020, W 2022, W 2024)
- THT 582 — Show Systems Engineering (W 2020, F 2021, F 2023) (redesigned course)
- THT 582 — Scenic Automation (F 2017)
- THP 500 — Conceiving the Production (F 2018)
- THF 501 — Research Methods (W 2018–19)
- THP 102 — Production Technique II (W 2017, 2021–24) (lighting section 2017; projection design section 2022–24)
- THP 202 — Production Technique IV (W 2018–24) (projection design section)
- THP 660 — Projection Design: Special Topics (W 2022) (created course)
- THF 101 — Elements of Production (F 2016, 2019, 2020)
- THM 301 — Technical Direction (F 2016)
- CRI 815 — Creative Impact Supercourse I, Creative Industries (F 2018)

Service

2026	Reviewer, NeurIPS Creative AI Track 2026: Agency, Thirty-Ninth Conference on Neural Information Processing Systems
2026-09 – present	School of Performance representative, TFA Representative's Council, TMU
2026-06 – present	Judge, Music, Film & Theatre panel, The Global Undergraduate Awards, Dublin
2026-04	Co-chair (with Dr. Afsoon Soudi), 3rd Annual Creative AI Symposium, Creative AI Hub, TMU
2025-07 – present	Member, Creative AI Hub Steering Committee, The Creative School, TMU
2025-02 – present	Member, USITT Research and Creative Endeavours Committee
2024-12 – present	Member, Faculty Tenure Committee, The Creative School, TMU
2025-04 – present	Board Member, UKAI Projects
2024-06 – present	Reviewer, International Journal of Performance Arts and Digital Media
2023-10 – present	Jury Member, CATR Scholarship and Grant Committee (Heather McCallum Scholarship, Robert Lawrence Scholarship, CATR Grants)
2023 – present	Reviewer, EVA London Conference on Electronic Visualisation and the Arts
2023 – 2024	Technical Advisory Board Member, UKAI Projects
2023 – 2024	Member, 360 Working Group, School of Performance, TMU
2023	Reviewer, Canada Foundation for Innovation
2022 – 2024	Senator (The Creative School faculty representative), TMU Senate
2022-03 – 2023	Secretary of the Board, Guild Festival Theatre
2021 – 2022	Member, Immersive Production Steering Committee, The Creative School, TMU
2021	Member, Name Implementation Advisory Group (FCAD renaming to The Creative School), TMU
2020 – 2023	Member, Gold Medal selection committee (FCAD/Creative School section), TMU

2020 – 2021	Member, Departmental Hiring Committee, Performance, TMU
2020 – present	Coordinator, Global Campus Studio course, TMU
2020	Member, FCAD Virtual Task Force, TMU
2020-09 – 2021-09	Member, Limited Return of Human Participant & Field SRC Activity Advisory Group, TMU
2019 – 2022	Member, Academic Integrity Committee, TMU
2018 – 2022	School of Performance representative, RFA (now TFA) Representative's Council, TMU
2018 – 2023	Member, Creative Innovation Studio Curatorial Committee, The Creative School, TMU
2018 – 2020	FCAD Teaching Committee; FCAD Interdisciplinary Advisory Committee
2017 – present	Member, Curriculum Committee, School of Performance, TMU
2017 – present	Member, Production Department Committee, School of Performance, TMU
2016 – 2021	Member, Stage Committee, Arts & Letters Club of Toronto

Memberships and Collectives

2025 – present	Canadian Artificial Intelligence Association
2023 – present	Almost Alchemy — improvised, multi-disciplinary performance collective (founding member)
2022 – 2023	Synectic Assembly — AI-driven art collective (founding member)
2021 – 2022	Diagonal — speaker series and reading group, BMO Lab, University of Toronto
2019 – present	United States Institute for Theatre Technology (USITT)
2018 – present	Associated Designers of Canada / IATSE Local ADC 659
2018 – present	Canadian Institute for Theatre Technology (CITT)

Interviews and Media

2023	"Get the inside scoop on game-changing innovations in augmented reality with the new VisionPro." The Creative School Top 5, July 4, 2023.
2023	Faculty Spotlight: Michael F Bergmann. Performance at The Creative School, June 27, 2023.
2022	"Students Are Excited And Hopeful For What The Metaverse May Bring." The Eyeopener, October 5, 2022.
2022	"Michael F. Bergmann On The Merging of Live Arts and Technology." Toronto Life, April 29, 2022.
2021	"Emerging technology that's here to stay." CityNews Toronto, June 18, 2021.

2020	“Can you feel empathy for a dancing robot?” Ryerson Innovation Magazine, Issue 33, 2020.
2020	“FCAD students embrace opportunity to redefine performance.” Nicole Bartnicki, Ryerson University, May 2020.
2019	“Premiere of robot dance performance launches Creative Technology Lab.” Ryerson University, November 2019.
2015	Q&A Personal interview, Meghan Perkins, Live Design Magazine, 2015.